

NAVAL SWORDS

An ordinary sailor in the late 18th century made do with a simple cutlass, alongside a boarding pike, axe, and blunderbuss pistol. Naval officers, however, could choose from a wider range of swords. In addition to a short, curved sword with a plain hilt, officers' weapons included the ceremonial small sword, often worn when going ashore, and the spadron – a light sword with a “five-ball hilt”. The spadron, with the decorative spheres on its hilt, was highly fashionable among officers in both armies and navies towards the close of the 18th century. Officers' swords also often had an anchor decoration on the hilt.



▲ SMALL SWORD

Date	1770
Origin	UK
Length	82.5cm (32½in)

This ceremonial small sword, which probably belonged to British diplomat Sir William Hamilton (1731–1803), had a silver knuckle guard and grip bound with silver wire. The ornate pommel was embossed with a motif of a goat and dogs.



▲ OFFICER'S DIRK

Date	1790
Origin	UK
Length	52cm (20½in)

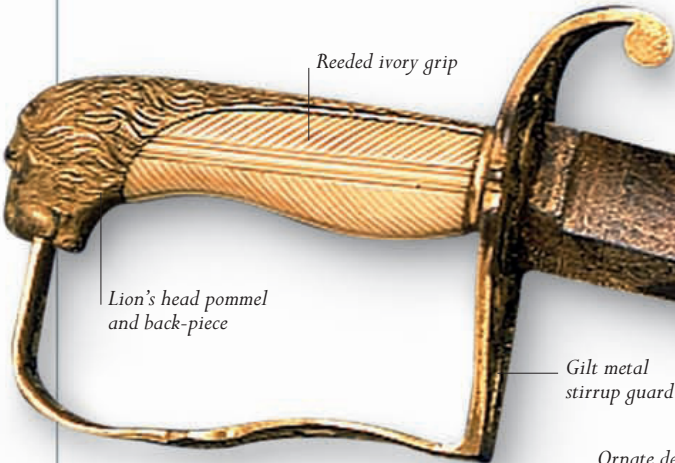
The dirk was carried by officers and midshipmen from 1750 onwards. The dagger-like sword could be used as a stabbing weapon in boarding operations.



► DUTCH S-BAR HILTED SWORD

Date	1797
Origin	Netherlands
Length	84cm (33in)

This Dutch sword with an S-bar hilt may have been given to Captain William Bligh by a Dutch admiral, perhaps Vice-Admiral Reijntjes, on board HMS *Director* in October 1797.



► NAVAL OFFICER'S SWORD

Date	1790
Origin	UK
Weight	935g (33oz)
Length	85cm (33½in)

Many of the ceremonial swords worn by naval officers featured etched designs, gilding, and a “blued” blade. Gold and mercury were used in the gilding, and when the blade was fired, the mercury evaporated, leaving the gold design highlighted against a dark background. English swordsmiths were renowned around the globe for their skill in these techniques.



▲ ROYAL MARINES SWORD

Date	c.1798
Origin	UK
Length	87cm (34¼in)

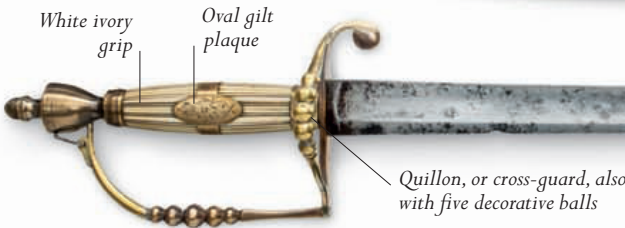
The British Royal Navy's corps of the Royal Marines was established in 1664. It was initially called the Duke of York and Albany's Maritime Regiment of Foot. Half the length of this fine sword's blade featured blue and gilt decoration.



► FIVE-BALL SPADRON

Date	c.1790
Origin	UK
Length	80.5cm (31½in)

This five-ball spadron, or light sword, was straight-bladed with a “five-ball hilt” – the “five-ball” referring to the decorative spheres on the hilt's knuckle guard and counter-guard.



Leather scabbard

Quillon, or cross-guard, also with five decorative balls